

Democratic Backsliding and State Repression

(GMAP 538A)

Spring 2026

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Time: Monday (17:50 - 20:50)
Place: Downtown Campus, 228

Objectives

This class will help explore scholarship from comparative politics, international relations, and political sociology that examines the causes, dynamics, and consequences of democratic backsliding and state repression. As we connect history, theory, and scholarship to contemporary politics, key questions will include: Why do democracies erode and what role do institutions, leaders, and citizens play in that process? How and why do governments employ repression, and with what consequences for political opposition and civil society? How do different regime types—democratic, authoritarian, and hybrid—shape the nature and extent of state repression?

By the end of this course, you should have a good understanding of the major theoretical debates about democratic decline and authoritarian entrenchment, along with cursory knowledge of how these processes have unfolded in a range of countries such as the United States, Hungary, Poland, Turkey, Venezuela, Russia, and beyond. While this is not a course in current events, I expect you to be attentive to ongoing developments in world politics. Even a minimal effort to follow contemporary trends – in light of the material covered in class – is likely to greatly increase your returns from this course.

Office Hours

I will be holding office hours every Friday from 10:00 to 12:00 in LNG 89 (Library North, Ground Floor). For an appointment, email me and we'll sort out a time. Be assured that our conversations will be held in the appropriate confidence; I am genuinely interested in each of you getting the most that you can out of this class.

Course Policies

- **Attendance and Participation:** Please, make all reasonable attempts to let me know of circumstances that may impact your ability to fulfill your course obligations as soon as possible. It is your responsibility to read carefully the assigned readings, to attend and participate in all class meetings/activities, and to write and turn in written assignments on time and in the appropriate format. I trust you will respect all in the

class by avoiding excessively late arrivals, repeated early exits, or otherwise disruptive behavior. I will assume that a) none of us would be so unscrupulous as to take unfair advantage of my – and others’ – willingness to be generous and flexible with each other and b) all of us will abide by the principle that honesty, integrity, and care for others in our communications and our scholarship is of paramount importance.

- **Accessibility:** If you have a documented disability, anticipate needing any type of accommodation in this course, or have questions/concerns about access, please tell me as soon as possible. Reasonable accommodations will be made for all students with disabilities, but it is your responsibility to inform me early in the term. I strongly encourage you to register any disability with the Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) Office.
- **Reporting Obligations:** In the event that you choose to disclose experiencing or surviving sexual violence, including sexual harassment, dating and domestic violence, sexual assault, stalking and rape, keep in mind that I am required, as your instructor, to notify the Title IX coordinator. Following my report to them, you will likely be contacted by email and provided with on- and off-campus resources and the option to speak with someone about your rights and available options.

If you would like to disclose your experience confidentially, contact the University Counseling Center, Decker Student Health Services Center, Harpur’s Ferry, the University Ombudsman or Binghamton University Interfaith Council (BUIC). For more information, visit the VARCC or Title IX Office. Additionally, I encourage you to take a look at our Binghamton Support Network, an online database of on- and off-campus resources.

- **Academic Integrity:** I, along with the Binghamton University, take violations of academic dishonesty very seriously. Observing honesty in one’s work, words, ideas, and actions is a principle to which all participants in this class are required to subscribe. All course work by students is to be done on an individual basis unless I clearly state that an alternative is acceptable. Any reference materials used in the preparation of any assignment must be explicitly cited. All in-text and bibliography citations should follow the guidelines of the American Political Science Association, as laid out in the APSA Style Manual for Political Science (2006) (available at <https://connect.apsanet.org/stylemanual/>). Students uncertain about proper citation are responsible for checking with me. Plagiarism, data falsification, lying to the instructor, or purposely misleading any University administrator all constitute actionable violations of academic integrity.
- **Copyright:** The lectures I deliver in this class and the course materials I create and distribute are protected by federal copyright law as my original works. My lectures are delivered from written lectures in order to ensure copyright protection. You are permitted to take notes of my lectures and use course materials only for your personal use in this course. You may not record, reproduce, or distribute my lectures/notes/materials for any commercial purpose and in any format (audio, photo, video, or written) without my written consent. Persons who sell or distribute copies or modified copies of my

course materials, possess commercial copies of my notes, or assist another person or entity in selling or distributing those materials may be considered in violation of the Academic Honesty Code.

Course Format

I have designed the course to maximize your flexibility in working through the material, communicating with each other, and completing your assignments.

- **Readings and Course Materials:** There are no required books for this course. Our reading list includes scholarly articles and book chapters, as well as some news articles, op-eds, or other popular media. In most cases you will be able to access them online. Occasionally I may distribute notes and/or reading guides to aid your comprehension. You should come to class prepared to discuss the items listed under each day. On days without a class meeting, the items listed are for you to engage in lieu of a seminar meeting. Some of the material will be technically and theoretically challenging (e.g., some of the scholarly articles utilize formal mathematical modeling and/or advanced statistics). I do not expect any of you to have any background in advanced research methods and, in most cases, my main concern is not in the technical details. Rather, my goal is for you to develop an intuitive understanding of the central arguments and conclusions and for you to be able to explain them.

Grading and Course Requirements

You have six major graded assignments in the following categories:

Assignment	Percentage
Attendance & Participation	15%
Midterm Exam	15%
Discussion Leading	15%
Movie Review	15%
Final Paper	40%
Total	100%

All written work must follow appropriate citation guidelines. Amended due dates and/or makeups will be granted in case of a emergency, illness, or excused absence. If you fall/feel ill or need to quarantine due to illness exposure, just email me!! Please keep yourself and others safe by not attending class while you are unwell.

Grade Scale

Grade	Points
A+	100-98
A	94-97
A-	93-90
B+	89-86
B	85-83
B-	82-80
C+	79-77
C	76-74
C-	73-70
D+	69-65
D	65-60
D-	59-55
F	<55

Assignment Details

Attendance & Participation (15 points)

Please, make all reasonable attempts to let me know of circumstances that may impact your ability to fulfill your course obligations as soon as possible. It is your responsibility to read carefully the assigned readings, to attend and participate in all class meetings/activities, and to write and turn in written assignments on time and in the appropriate format. I trust you will respect all in the class by avoiding excessively late arrivals, repeated early exits, or otherwise disruptive behavior. I am just going to assume that a) none of us would be so unscrupulous as to take unfair advantage of my – and others' – willingness to be generous and flexible with each other and b) all of us will abide by the principle that honesty, integrity, and care for others in our communications and our scholarship is of paramount importance.

Midterm Exam (15 points)

The midterm exam is designed to demonstrate how well you understand the foundational concepts. They will be multiple choice/short answer in format. Midterm exam will be held during the first half of class on March 16th. The format will be multiple-choice and short-answer, focusing on foundational concepts.

Important: The exam will be composed exclusively of questions drawn from our shared Google Doc. To facilitate this, I will seed the document with sample questions, and each student is required to contribute at least an original question to the pool. By participating, you are directly shaping the exam you will take.

Discussion Leading (15 points)

Each week, two students will lead the discussion section. Discussion leaders are responsible for carefully reading all assigned materials for that week, preparing a set of thoughtful discussion questions in advance, and identifying key arguments, methods, and forms of evidence

used in the readings. They should be ready to explain what they found most compelling or problematic, to offer constructive criticisms, and to point out what they liked or found convincing in the work. I will support and guide discussion leaders as needed, but they are expected to take primary responsibility for structuring and initiating the conversation. During the first week of class, a sign-up sheet will be distributed. Each student must select one week in which they will serve as a discussion leader. Every week must have two student leaders.

Movie Review (15 points)

You will write a critical review (5-6 pages each, standard formatting) of one of the films on our syllabus. These papers are not to be film summaries. Rather, they are meant to engage your ability to synthesize and critique the material in the film in light of our course materials. For example, you might discuss how the film delves further into a key definition or dynamic that we discussed in class (or not), addresses unanswered questions, or highlights something new that you hadn't yet considered. You should run your off-syllabus film choice past me no later than Mar 23. The papers are due by April, 24.

Movies are:

- No (2012)
- The Lives of Others (2006)
- Persepolis (2007)
- 4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days (2007)
- Hotel Rwanda (2004)
- Missing (1982)
- Good Bye Lenin! (2003)
- Bloody Sunday (2002)
- The Act of Killing (2012)
- The Reader (2008)
- Come and See (1985)
- Incendies (2010)
- Burning Days (2022)

Final Paper (40 points)

You will write a final (research) paper on state repression. All written assignments should be double-spaced and use a 12-point font, Times New Roman. The final paper should be around 15–20 pages. A draft of the final paper (5 pages) is due on April, 10 and will count for 5% of the total course grade (out of the 40% allocated to the final paper). The completed final paper is due on May, 11. I will provide writing guidance throughout the semester to help you prepare both your draft and your final submission.

Course Schedule

Week 1 (Jan 26): Introductions, Review of Course Schedule and Policies, Political Regimes

Required Readings

- Schmitter, Philippe C., and Terry Lynn Karl. “What democracy is... and is not.” *Journal of democracy* 2, (1991): 75-88.
- Cheibub, José Antonio, Jennifer Gandhi, and James Raymond Vreeland. “Democracy and dictatorship revisited.” *Public choice* 143, (2010): 67-101.
- Reich, Gary. “Categorizing political regimes: New data for old problems.” *Democratization* 9, no. 4 (2002): 1-24.

Week 2 (Feb 2): Authoritarian Regimes

Required Readings

- Magaloni, Beatriz. “Credible power-sharing and the longevity of authoritarian rule.” *Comparative political studies* 41, no. 4-5 (2008): 715-741.
- Boix, Carles, and Milan W. Svolik. “The foundations of limited authoritarian government: Institutions, commitment, and power-sharing in dictatorships.” *The Journal of Politics* 75, (2013): 300-316.
- Gandhi, Jennifer, and Adam Przeworski. “Authoritarian institutions and the survival of autocrats.” *Comparative political studies* 40, (2007): 1279-1301.
- Bellin, Eva. “Reconsidering the robustness of authoritarianism in the Middle East: Lessons from the Arab Spring.” *Comparative Politics* 44, (2012): 127-149.

Recommended Readings

- Montagnes, B. Pablo, and Stephane Wolton. “Mass purges: Top-down accountability in autocracy.” *American Political Science Review* 113, (2019): 1045-1059.

- Ross, Michael L. “Oil, Islam, and women.” *American political science review* 102, (2008): 107-123.
- Smith, Benjamin. “Oil wealth and regime survival in the developing world, 1960–1999.” *American Journal of Political Science* 48, (2004): 232-246.
- Schedler, Andreas. “Elections without democracy: The menu of manipulation.” *Journal of democracy* 13, (2002): 36-50.
- Svobik, Milan W. “Power sharing and leadership dynamics in authoritarian regimes.” *American Journal of Political Science* 53, (2009): 477-494.
- Nathan, Andrew J. “China’s changing of the guard: Authoritarian resilience.” *Journal of democracy* 14, no. 1 (2003): 6-17.

Week 3 (Feb 9): Democracy

Required Readings

- Schedler, Andreas. “What is democratic consolidation?.” *Journal of democracy* 9, no. 2 (1998): 91-107.
- Linz, Juan J. “The perils of presidentialism.” *Journal of democracy* 1, (1990): 51-69.
- Tsebelis, George. “Decision making in political systems: Veto players in presidentialism, parliamentarism, multicameralism and multipartyism.” *British journal of political science* 25, no. 3 (1995): 289-325.
- Munck, Gerardo L. “What is democracy? A reconceptualization of the quality of democracy.” *Democratization* 23, (2016): 1-26.

Recommended Readings

- Lijphart, Arend. “Constitutional choices for new democracies.” *Journal of democracy* 2, no. 1 (1991): 72-84.
- Przeworski, Adam, and Fernando Limongi. “Modernization: Theories and facts.” *World politics* 49, no. 2 (1997): 155-183.

Week 4 (Feb 16): Hybrid Regimes

Required Readings

- Bogaards, Matthijs. “How to classify hybrid regimes? Defective democracy and electoral authoritarianism.” *Democratization* 16, (2009): 399-423.
- Levitsky, Steven, and Lucan A. Way. “Elections without democracy: The rise of competitive authoritarianism.” *Journal of democracy* 13, no. 2 (2002): 51-65.

- Morse, Yonatan L. “The era of electoral authoritarianism.” *World politics* 64, no. 1 (2012): 161-198.
- Diamond, Larry. “Elections without democracy: Thinking about hybrid regimes.” *Journal of democracy* 13, (2002): 21-34.

Week 5 (Feb 23): Democratic Backsliding

Required Readings

- Little, Andrew T., and Anne Meng. “Measuring democratic backsliding.” *PS: Political Science & Politics* 57, (2024): 149-161.
- Waldner, David, and Ellen Lust. “Unwelcome change: Coming to terms with democratic backsliding.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 21, no. 1 (2018): 93-113.
- Bermeo, Nancy. “On democratic backsliding.” *Journal of democracy* 27, (2016): 5-19.
- Kneuer, Marianne. “Unravelling democratic erosion: who drives the slow death of democracy, and how?.” *Democratization* 28, (2021): 1442-1462.

Week 6 (Mar 2): What is State Repression?

Required Readings

- Davenport, Christian, and Molly Inman. “The state of state repression research since the 1990s.” *Terrorism and Political Violence* 24, no. 4 (2012): 619-634.
- Davenport, Christian. “State repression and political order.” *Annu. Rev. Polit. Sci.* 10, (2007): 1-23.
- Chenoweth, Erica, Evan Perkoski, and Sooyeon Kang. “State repression and nonviolent resistance.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 61, no. 9 (2017): 1950-1969.
- Davenport, Christian, and Benjamin J. Appel. “Stopping state repression: An examination of spells.” *Journal of Peace Research* 59, no. 5 (2022): 633-647.

Week 7 (Mar 9): Why States Repress?

Required Readings

- Grasse, Donald, Melissa Pavlik, Hilary Matfess, and Travis B. Curtice. “Opportunistic repression: Civilian targeting by the state in response to COVID-19.” *International Security* 46, (2021): 130-165.
- Mehrl, Marius, Mila Pfander, Theresa Winner, and Cornelius Fritz. “Guardians of the Regime: When and Why Autocrats Create Secret Police.” *arXiv preprint* (2025).
- Ritter, Emily Hencken. “Policy disputes, political survival, and the onset and severity of state repression.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 58, no. 1 (2014): 143-168.

- Davenport, Christian. “Multi-dimensional threat perception and state repression: An inquiry into why states apply negative sanctions.” *American Journal of Political Science* (1995): 683-713.

Recommended Readings

- Ellefsen, Rune, and Jan Jämte. “The causes, content and consequences of repression: A framework for analyzing protest control in the counter-extremism era.” *Social Movement Studies* 22, (2023): 567-582.

Week 8 (Mar 16): Repression Types (I)

Required Readings

- Bell, Sam R., David Cingranelli, Amanda Murdie, and Alper Caglayan. “Coercion, capacity, and coordination: Predictors of political violence.” *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 30, (2013): 240-262.
- Aguilar, Paloma, and Iosif Kovras. “Explaining disappearances as a tool of political terror.” *International Political Science Review* 40, (2019): 437-452.
- Cingranelli, David L., and David L. Richards. “The Cingranelli and Richards (CIRI) human rights data project.” *Human rights quarterly* 32, no. 2 (2010): 401-424.
- Shen-Bayh, Fiona. “Strategies of repression: Judicial and extrajudicial methods of autocratic survival.” *World Politics* 70, no. 3 (2018): 321-357.

Recommended Readings

- Taylor, Charles Fernandes, Jon CW Pevehouse, and Scott Straus. “Perils of pluralism: Electoral violence and incumbency in sub-Saharan Africa.” *Journal of Peace Research* 54, no. 3 (2017): 397-411.

Week 9 (Mar 23): Repression Types (II)

Required Readings

- Steinert, Christoph V., and Christoph Dworschak. “Political imprisonment and protest mobilization: Evidence from the GDR.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 67, (2023): 1564-1591.
- Conrad, Courtenay Ryals, and Will H. Moore. “What stops the torture?.” *American Journal of Political Science* 54, (2010): 459-476.
- Pan, Jennifer, and Alexandra A. Siegel. “How Saudi crackdowns fail to silence online dissent.” *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 1 (2020): 109-125.

- Einolf, Christopher J. “How torture fails: Evidence of misinformation from torture-induced confessions in Iraq.” *Journal of Global Security Studies* 7, no. 1 (2022): ogab019.

Recommended Readings

- Beger, Andreas, and Daniel Hill Jr. “Examining repressive and oppressive state violence using the Ill-Treatment and Torture data.” *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 36, (2019): 626-644.
- Bove, Vincenzo, and Mauricio Rivera. “Elite co-optation, repression, and coups in autocracies.” *International Interactions* 41, no. 3 (2015): 453-479.

Week 10 (Mar 30): No Class (Spring Break)

Week 11 (Apr 7): Repression Types (III)

Required Readings

- Mattingly, Daniel C., and Elaine Yao. “How soft propaganda persuades.” *Comparative Political Studies* 55, (2022): 1569-1594.
- Huang, Haifeng. “Propaganda as signaling.” *Comparative Politics* 47, (2015): 419-444.
- Rosenfeld, Bryn, and Jeremy Wallace. “Information politics and propaganda in authoritarian societies.” *Annual Review of Political Science* (2024)
- Roberts, Margaret E. “Resilience to online censorship.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 23, (2020): 401-419.

Recommended Readings

- Yavuz, Mehmet. “Crises and Ideological Change in Authoritarian Regimes: Evidence From the July 2016 Coup Attempt in Turkey.” *Comparative Political Studies* (2024): 00104140251369324.

Week 12 (Apr 13): Justification of State Repression

Required Readings

- Edel, Mirjam, and Maria Josua. “How authoritarian rulers seek to legitimize repression: framing mass killings in Egypt and Uzbekistan.” *Democratization* 25, (2018): 882-900.
- Josua, Maria. “Justifications of repression in autocracies: an empirical analysis of Morocco and Tunisia, 2000–2010.” *Contemporary Politics* 30, (2024): 108-136.
- Josua, Maria, and Mirjam Edel. “The Arab uprisings and the return of repression.” *Mediterranean Politics* 26, no. 5 (2021): 586-611.

- Lachapelle, Jean. “Repression reconsidered: Bystander effects and legitimation in authoritarian regimes.” *Comparative Politics* 54, (2022): 695-716.

Recommended Readings

- Bray, Laura A., Thomas E. Shriver, and Alison E. Adams. “Framing authoritarian legitimacy: elite cohesion in the aftermath of popular rebellion.” *Social Movement Studies* 18, (2019): 682-701.

Week 13 (Apr 20): State Repression in Different Political Regimes (I)

Required Readings

- Davenport, Christian. “State repression and the tyrannical peace.” *Journal of Peace Research* 44, (2007): 485-504.
- Skaaning, Svend-Erik. “More violent state repression in hybrid regimes? A comprehensive assessment based on continuous and categorical distinctions.” *Zeitschrift für Vergleichende Politikwissenschaft* (2025): 1-33.
- Regan, Patrick M., and Errol A. Henderson. “Democracy, threats and political repression in developing countries: are democracies internally less violent?” *Third World Quarterly* 23, no. 1 (2002): 119-136.
- Samet, Oren. “When you come at the king: Opposition coalitions and nearly stunning elections.” *American Journal of Political Science* 69, no. 4 (2025): 1469-1485.

Recommended Readings

- Esberg, Jane. “Anticipating dissent: The repression of politicians in Pinochet’s Chile.” *The Journal of Politics* 83, (2021): 689-705.
- Young, Lauren E. “Who dissents? Self-efficacy and opposition action after state-sponsored election violence.” *Journal of Peace Research* 57, (2020): 62-76.

Week 14 (Apr 27): State Repression in Different Political Regimes (II)

Required Readings

- Wright, Thorin M. “Territorial revision and state repression.” *Journal of Peace Research* 51, (2014): 375-387.
- Aytaç, S. Erdem, Luis Schiumerini, and Susan Stokes. “Protests and repression in new democracies.” *Perspectives on Politics* 15, no. 1 (2017): 62-82.

- Olar, Roman-Gabriel. “Do they know something we don’t? Diffusion of repression in authoritarian regimes.” *Journal of Peace Research* 56, no. 5 (2019): 667-681.
- Bhasin, Tavishi, and Jennifer Gandhi. “Timing and targeting of state repression in authoritarian elections.” *Electoral Studies* 32, (2013): 620-631.

Recommended Readings

- Edwards, Pearce. “Political Competition and Authoritarian Repression: Evidence from Pinochet’s Chile.” *World Politics* 74, (2022): 479-522.
- Berman, Chantal E. “Policing the organizational threat in Morocco: Protest and public violence in liberal autocracies.” *American Journal of Political Science* 65, no. 3 (2021): 733-754.

Week 15 (May 4): Responses to State Repression

Required Readings

- Ang, Desmond, and Jonathan Tebes. “Civic responses to police violence.” *American Political Science Review* 118, (2024): 972-987.
- LeBas, Adrienne, and Lauren E. Young. “Repression and dissent in moments of uncertainty: Panel data evidence from Zimbabwe.” *American Political Science Review* 118, (2024): 584-601.
- Sullivan, Christopher Michael, and Christian Davenport. “The rebel alliance strikes back: Understanding the politics of backlash mobilization.” *Mobilization* 22, (2017): 39-56.
- Honari, Ali. “From ‘the effect of repression’ toward ‘the response to repression’.” *Current Sociology* 66, no. 6 (2018): 950-973.